

27 Financial risk management (continued)

– debt to assets ratio

£m – including Group's share of joint ventures	Group 2019	Group 2018
Market value of investment and development property	6,633.3	9,167.4
Net external debt	(4,498.4)	(4,867.2)
Debt to assets ratio	67.8%	53.1%

Taking into account the net proceeds from the sale of intu Asturias and intu Puerto Venecia of £163.7 million (see note 32), the debt to assets ratio would be 65.3 per cent.

– interest cover

£m – including Group's share of joint ventures	Group 2019	Group 2018
Finance costs	(227.5)	(223.0)
Less amortisation of Metrocentre compound financial instrument	5.9	5.9
Finance income	2.9	2.6
	(218.7)	(214.5)
Underlying operating profit	364.7	409.4
Interest cover	1.67x	1.91x

28 Share capital and share premium

£m	Share capital	Share premium
Authorised, issued and fully paid:		
At 31 December 2019 and 31 December 2018: 1,355,040,243 ordinary shares of 50 pence each	677.5	1,327.4

Full details of the rights and obligations attaching to the ordinary shares are contained in the Company's articles of association. These rights include an entitlement to receive the Company's annual report and financial statements, to attend and speak at general meetings of the Company, to appoint proxies and to exercise voting rights. Holders of ordinary shares may also receive dividends and may receive a share of the Company's assets on the Company's liquidation. There are no restrictions on the transfer of the ordinary shares.

At 26 February 2019 the Company had an unexpired authority to repurchase shares up to a maximum of 135,504,024 shares with a nominal value of £67.8 million, and the directors have an unexpired authority to allot up to a maximum of 451,608,081 shares with a nominal value of £225.8 million.

Included within the issued share capital at 31 December 2019 are 10,325,626 ordinary shares (2018: 11,216,115) held by the Trustee of the ESOP which is operated by the Company (see note 29). The nominal value of these shares at 31 December 2019 is £5.2 million (2018: £5.6 million).

29 Employee Share Ownership Plan (ESOP)

The cost of shares in intu properties plc held by the Trustee of the ESOP operated by the Company is accounted for as a deduction from equity.

The purpose of the ESOP is to acquire and hold shares which will be transferred to employees in the future under the Group's employee incentive arrangements as described in note 7 including joint ownership of shares in its role as Trustee of the Joint Share Ownership Plan. During 2019, no dividends in respect of these shares have been waived by agreement (2018: £1.6 million).

	2019		2018	
	Shares million	£m	Shares million	£m
At 1 January	11.2	37.0	11.6	39.1
Acquisitions	0.2	0.1	0.6	0.9
Disposals	(1.1)	(3.5)	(1.0)	(3.0)
At 31 December	10.3	33.6	11.2	37.0